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> **"MY BROTHER HAS BRIEFED ME, BUT I WANT TO COME TO YOUR HOUSE, UNDERSTAND WHAT YOUR ISSUES ARE"**
>
> **PRIYANKA GANDHI**
> **Wayanad LS candidate**

but then settled for software engineer-turned-neta and Kozhikode Corporation councillor Navya Haridas.

Priyanka will not have it easy. The LDF and BJP are already questioning Rahul's contribution to Wayanad, dubbing him a "tourist MP who never raised issues related to the constituency". The people will also want to know what all three sides in the fray have done to rehabilitate the victims of the July landslides. In its defence, the Congress will parrot the BJP line that the Pinarayi Vijayan government faked data on losses to get funds and misused it. PM Narendra Modi had visited the disaster-affected areas in August, but relief funds have been a trickle, a fact that the Kerala High Court has also taken the Centre to task for.

The people in Wayanad don't have much hope from any party. "We were forced into this bypoll," says Augustine Joseph, 39, a farmer in Bathery. "Our fate is not going to change, whoever wins." The low prices of their agri produce, debt trap and farmer suicides, a defunct medical college, the ban on night travel from Wayanad to Karnataka (due to the wildlife corridors) hitting commerce, these are some of the pressing everyday issues here.

Still, the region is in an upbeat mood now, and Priyanka's arrival has a lot to do with it. As a star-struck Thresiya put it, "She's the living embodiment of Indira (the late PM and Priyanka's grandmother). It's like I have got another daughter." If she wins, Wayanad will be hoping the new daughter spends some more time here and represents its interests a lot more in Delhi. ■

RAJASTHAN

THE MINISTER PROVOCATEUR

By Rohit Parihar

Known for shooting from the hip rather too often, Rajasthan education minister Madan Dilawar again finds himself embroiled in controversy, this time over his remarks about the attire of teachers. Addressing a gathering in Neem Ka Thana on October 16, Dilawar criticised women teachers for wearing what he deemed inappropriate clothing that revealed too much of their bodies. As his comments sparked a fierce backlash, the 65-year-old Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) veteran called those opposing his views "duffer", claiming that his intent was simply to encourage teachers to set a good example for their students.



MADAN DILAWAR
Rajasthan education minister

But even some within his party have distanced themselves from his comments. BJP legislator Suresh Dhakar, for one, voiced his support for protesting teachers and suggested that Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma should advise Dilawar to be more respectful in his statements. Another BJP leader, talking to INDIA TODAY, even sarcastically wondered if Dilawar wanted women teachers to wear a burqa.